

Start Strong: Part II– January 11, 2025

I. Welcome!

If you are a first-time guest or you are wanting to plug in more to weekly virtual prayer meetings, our Wednesday night small groups, serving, or membership—*Fill out our digital connect card to stay connected!*



II. Announcements:



Sign up for Virtual Small Groups!

Start your year with momentum by jumping into our Start Strong four-week Formation Track! Virtual small groups will meet via Zoom on Wednesdays from 8:00–9:15 PM, running January 14- February 4.

Weekly Prayer Rhythms Start Tomorrow! Grab a Start Strong Prayer Guide in the lobby!

III. Start Strong, Part II — Sell All for the Ultimate Riches, Hazen Stevens

Key Theme

The Kingdom of God is of such surpassing value that surrendering everything for it is not loss, but joy. We Stay Strong by fixing our hearts on the joy waiting on the other side of the painful sojourn.

Key Scripture: Hebrews 12:1–2

I. The Kingdom's Hidden Value

Truth: Some things reveal their true worth only with time and insight.

Matthew 13:44 (WEB)

The Kingdom of Heaven is like treasure hidden in a field. When a man finds it, he sells all he has and buys the field—in joy.

Insight

- The treasure is not obvious to everyone
- The man sells everything not reluctantly, but joyfully

II. The Pearl of Ultimate Worth

Matthew 13:45–46 (WEB)

A merchant searching for fine pearls finds one of great price, sells all he has, and buys it.

Insight: The merchant recognizes unequal value. Once true worth is seen, total surrender becomes the only rational response

III. The Inversion of the Kingdom

Key Principle

What appears to be reckless loss is actually wise investment.

Surrender is not the suppression of desire; it is the fulfillment of it.

The Kingdom does not ask us to want less—it offers us more than we imagined.

IV. Earthly Parables of Misjudged Treasure

Illustration: The Black Prince's Ruby

- Once sold as a common stone because its value was unseen
- Now considered beyond monetary calculation

Kingdom Parallel

The Kingdom can be dismissed by those who do not recognize it.

To the one who sees, any cost is worth paying.

V. Total Sacrifice for Temporary Treasure

Illustration: Mel Fisher and the Atocha

- Gave years, wealth, reputation, and endured profound loss
- Found treasure worth hundreds of millions and was celebrated

Question Jesus Raises

If people sacrifice everything for treasure that fades, what should we give for what is eternal?

VI. We Want Too Little, Not Too Much

Core Insight

We cling to small pleasures because we cannot imagine infinite joy.

Matthew 6:19–20 (WEB)

Do not store up treasures on earth, but store up treasures in heaven.

Truth

Rejecting eternal treasure is not choosing nothing—it is choosing something far less.

VII. Selling All Before the World Understands

Key Reality

- The merchant bought the pearl before others could see its worth
- Kingdom obedience often precedes visible reward

Final Question

Have you seen the treasure clearly enough to release what you're holding—even when others cannot yet see its value?

Reminder: Connect this Week with Virtual Prayer!